

STREETS OF YOTSUYA

Narrative Design Document – Opening Sequence

Chapter 0: Pre-Title Sequence / Tutorial

1. Scene Overview

Setting

A late-night onsen in Tokyo. Private, humid, almost silent. It works as a space of temporary suspension from the city outside.

Time

Pre-dawn. The city has not woken up yet.

Narrative Function

The opening sequence introduces the protagonist through memory before introducing the world through threat. The transition from flashback to present establishes tone, character and the stakes of the experience before the player is asked to make a single decision.

Gameplay Function

Tutorial. The player's first interaction determines their approach profile for a significant portion of the game. The branching point is not a menu choice but it is a perceptual moment. When and how the player notices the threat defines which option becomes available to them.

2. Narrative Context

The Protagonist

Male, mid-twenties. Passionate about cars and underground drift racing: a world he knows intimately. He is not a criminal or a fighter. He is actually a troublemaker by temperament rather than profession: a person who moves fast, reads people quickly, and occasionally fails to consider consequences.

He does not own a gun. He is not trained (yet, concept under evaluation). His main feature relies on his instinct, improvisation, and an intimate knowledge of cars.

The Flashback

As the protagonist sits in the onsen, steam in the air, a bottle of Asahi in hand, memories appear.

He is a kid inside a bar in his neighborhood. His father, a man with a drinking problem and an easy laugh, standing at the counter in front of a wall of smoke. The owner, known only as Bronco almost appear just as a voice and a glowing cigarette tip, barely visible. A daily ritual consists in a large beer for the father and a mango ice pop for the kid. A 80's Supra waiting outside.

The flashback is not nostalgic. It carries the specific texture of something important that no longer exists. The protagonist is alone in a way that the memory makes legible.

The transition out of the flashback is sensory: the steam of the onsen bleeds into the smoke of the bar. The same air, a different world.

The Threat

The onsen attendant has gone silent. The small sounds that constituted the background: movement, a distant television, the rhythm of a working space, have stopped.

Someone has come in through a secondary entrance. The attendant has been dealt with: removed, neutralized or fled. The protagonist does not know this yet.

The intruder is a professional: he moves without sound and he is not there by accident.

3. The Object

The protagonist's only available improvised weapon is the bottle of Asahi he was drinking from when the sequence began.

This detail connects the flashback directly to the present moment. The object associated with his father, with Bronco, with a particular kind of lost warmth, becomes the only thing standing between him and a professional killer.

The player does not need to understand this consciously for the moment.

4. Branching Structure

The three gameplay options do not appear as a menu. They emerge from a perceptual sequence: the earlier the player notices the threat, the more options remain available. The branching point is attention, not reaction.

	EARLY — Stealth	MID — Chaotic	LATE — Diplomatic
Trigger	Player notices the silence before the intruder reaches proximity. A door left ajar. The absence of sound that should be there.	Player notices movement or shadow at close range. The intruder is already near. Seconds available.	Player does not notice in time. The intruder is present with weapon drawn before the protagonist reacts.
Action	Hide. Move through the onsen using the environment. Reach the exit without direct confrontation.	Use the bottle. Break it, attack, create chaos. Survive the immediate encounter through force and noise.	Put the bottle down. Raise hands. Attempt to talk.
Immediate Outcome	Exits without being identified. The intruder finds an empty room. The MC leaves by car, the intruder's associates understand he is leaving, but it is not the difficult to escape.	Neutralizes the immediate threat. Loud. The intruder's associates outside are alerted. A car chase begins in worse conditions, but after while if the player drove well, the MC can escape.	Survives the encounter. The intruder, surprised by compliance, does not fire immediately. Protagonist is seen, identified, remembered. The intruder talks, telling why they are looking for the MC.
Long-term Cost	There is a threat that will be shown later in the story. The intruder will be more cautious.	The chase pisses off the intruder and its associates. The situation will start a violent manhunt, who forces the MC to be more cautious.	The protagonist is abducted and brought to the intruder's criminal association. Reasons of the chase are still unknown.

Gameplay Impact	Opens stealth-oriented progression paths. Certain contacts trust the protagonist more. Information becomes a primary resource.	Opens confrontation-oriented paths. Reputation in racing and underground circuits increases.	Severely constrains early options. Recovery is possible but costly.
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Note:

The Diplomatic option is not intended as a death state. It is the most costly path, not because talking is wrong, but because compliance in this context signals something specific to the people watching. The game does not punish communication, but punishes the particular kind of conflict avoidance that comes from fear rather than strategy.

5. The Escape

Except for the "Diplomatic" option, the sequence ends with the protagonist in his car, a battered Toyota AE86, leaving the onsen at speed. Two vehicles follow, carrying the intruder's associates.

The tutorial driving sequence plays out here. A near-miss or collision with a parked vehicle depending on player performance. The city is empty. The engine fills the streets. The sun is rising ahead of him.

Title Card Sequence

The camera pulls back from the protagonist's POV, revealing the interior of the car, then arcing outward to show the vehicle moving through the waking city from above.

Title on screen: STREETS OF YOTSUYA.

The daylight, in this context, is not reassuring. It is overexposed and disorienting, a nightmare for someone who has not slept and is now moving through a world that operates on rhythms he no longer shares.

6. Tone and Direction

Audio

The sequence is built on absence before presence. The missing background sounds inside the onsen, is the first signal. Music enters only once inside the car: Personal Jesus - Depeche Mode.

Visual

Steam, shadow, reflections in water. The intruder is never fully visible until the confrontation point. The player sees what the protagonist sees, and the protagonist sees what the player pays attention to.

Design Intention

The opening sequence is intended to establish that this is a world where attention is a survival skill. The player who notices what is wrong before being told to notice it will move through the game differently from the player who waits for a prompt. Both paths are valid. Neither is without cost.